

Flow — User Guide

5and8 pipeline desktop · every screen, step by step.

Flow is the desktop app artists open at the start of the day. It signs you in, shows the projects you are on, launches the DCCs with the project environment already set, and carries your task context into Maya, Nuke, Houdini, Blender, Silhouette, Substance, Rhino and 3DEqualizer so that saving, versioning and publishing land in the right folders without anyone typing a path.

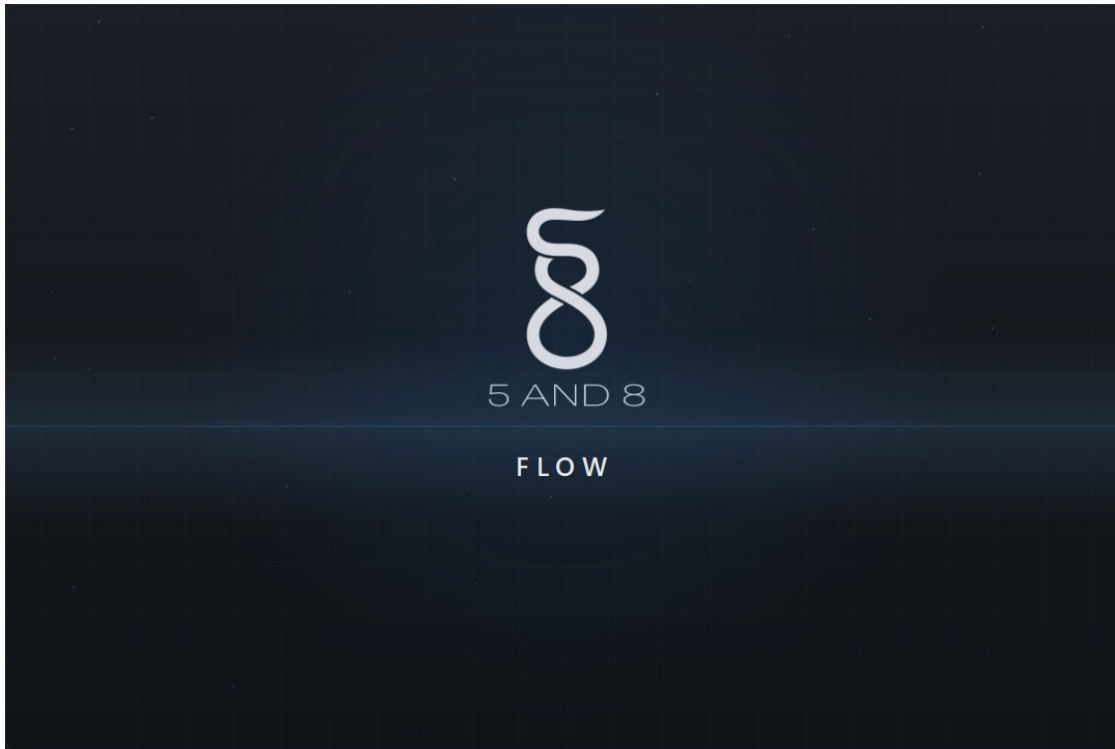
This guide walks every screen in the order you meet it. Each section is a numbered procedure followed by the screen it applies to.

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1. Starting Flow and signing in

1. Launch **Flow** from the desktop launcher, or run `flow.sh` from a terminal.
2. The splash appears while Flow authenticates you and contacts ShotGrid. The status line under the wordmark says which step it is on — *Loading Pipeline, Connecting to ShotGrid, Preparing Workspace*.
3. On a domain-joined workstation you are signed in silently with your Active Directory login and never see a prompt. Go to step 5.
4. Otherwise the sign-in dialog opens. Type your workstation username and password and press **Sign in**. Only members of the studio's authorised AD group can get in; anyone else is refused with a message rather than a half-working window.
5. The main window fades in behind the splash, already on the projects screen.



The splash: 5and8 wordmark, product name, and the current startup step.

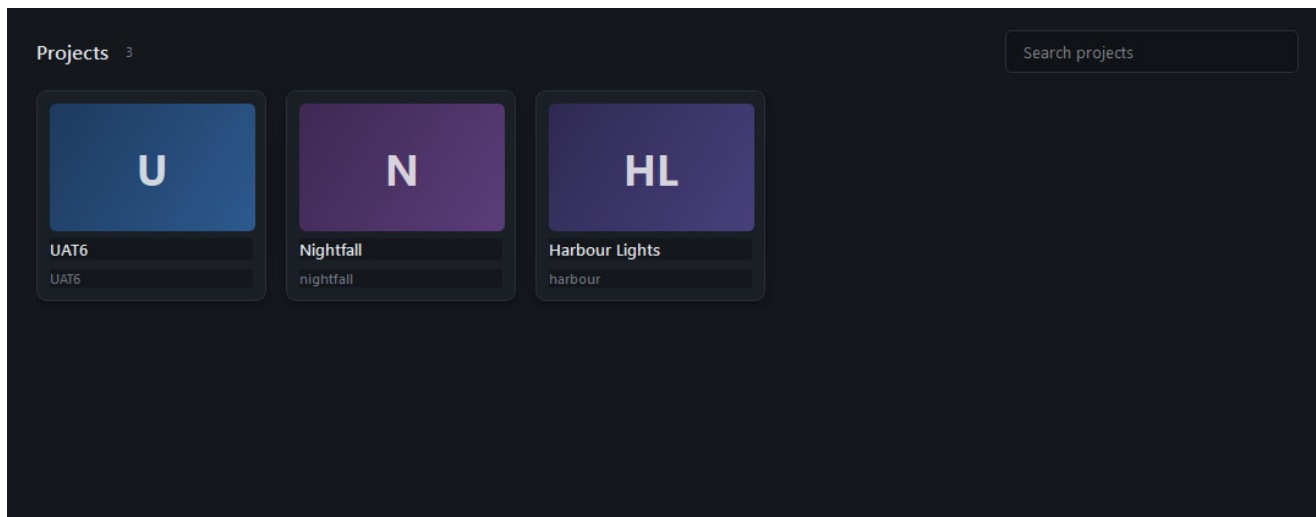
A dark blue sign-in dialog box with white text. At the top, it says 'Sign in to 5and8.net'. Below that, it says 'Use your workstation login. Members of ai-users only.' There are two input fields: 'Username' with the hint '5AND8\username' and 'Password' with the hint 'Password'. At the bottom right, there are two buttons: 'Sign in' and 'Cancel'.

Sign-in, shown only when Windows/AD single sign-on is not available. The username hint shows the domain prefix your site expects.

If sign-in fails Flow stops rather than continuing unauthenticated: you get one dialog naming the reason (not in the authorised group, wrong password, domain controller unreachable). Nothing in the app is reachable until it succeeds.

2. Choosing a project

1. The projects screen lists every **Active** project you can see, as tiles. The count sits next to the heading.
2. Type in **Search projects** to narrow the grid — it matches on the project name and on the short code under it.
3. Click a tile to open the project.
4. The header then shows Flow > <project>, and a < **Projects** button appears on the left to come back here.



Projects. The small grey line under each name is the project's short code — the folder name on disk.

3. The header bar

The header is the same on every screen inside a project.

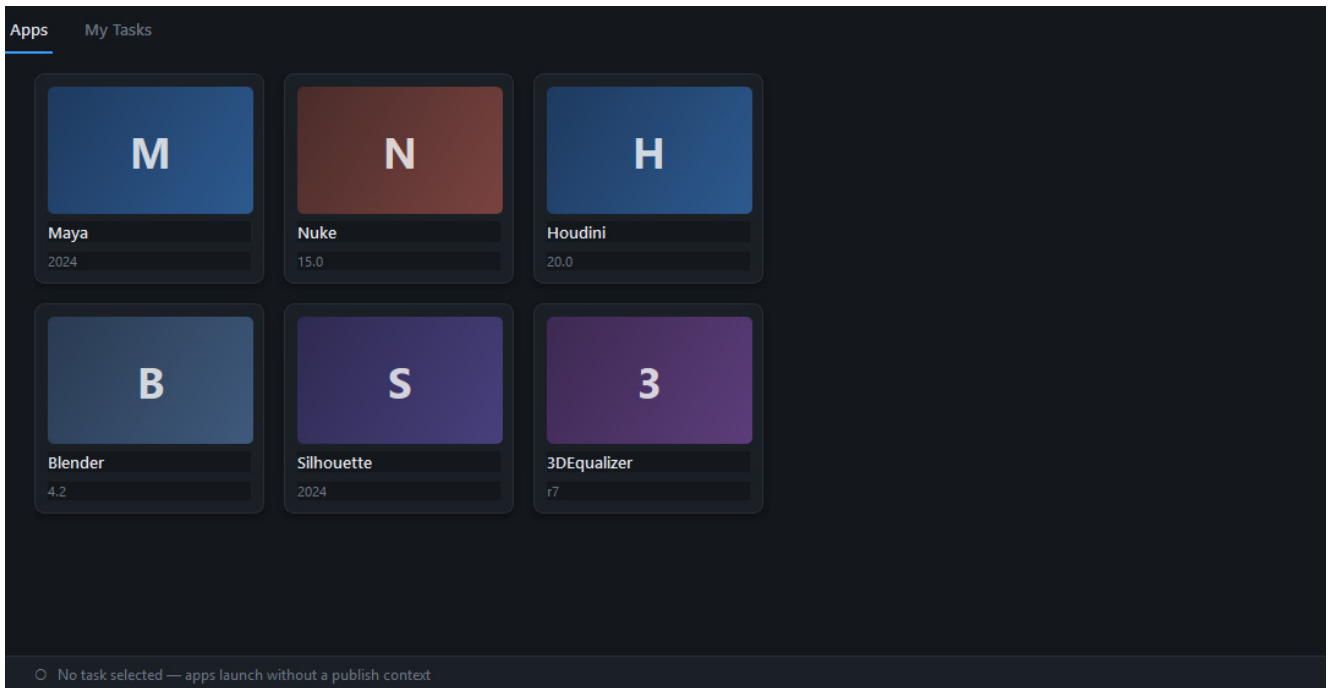
Control	What it does
< Projects	Back to the project grid.
Breadcrumb	Flow > <project> — which show you are in.
Search my tasks	Find a task across <i>all</i> your projects without remembering which show it is on. Ctrl+K focuses it; pick a result and Flow opens that project and selects the task for you.
Needs Attention	Toggles the review screen (section 13). The button carries the unread count, so you can see there is feedback without going looking for it.
Terminal	Shows what Flow is running in the background (section 14). Ctrl+` .
Your name chip	Click for the profile menu: name, login, email, how you were signed in (AD single sign-on, password, developer override), the domain, and which ShotGrid <i>HumanUser</i> your email matched. If that last row says no user matched, your tasks will be empty — see section 16.

4. The Apps tab — launching software

1. Open a project. It lands on **Apps**.
2. Each tile is a piece of software your studio has configured for this show, with its version underneath.
3. Click a tile to launch it. Flow builds the environment first (studio defaults, then the project's own settings), then starts the application detached — closing Flow afterwards does not kill it.
4. Watch the status line at the bottom, or open the **Terminal** pane, to see the exact command and environment it used.

Launching from this tab carries no task. The status bar says so: *No task selected — apps launch without a publish context.*

Save, Version Up and Publish inside the DCC all need a task, so if you intend to work on a shot, launch from **My Tasks** (section 7) instead.



The Apps tab. Tiles come from the Software entities in ShotGrid; ones with no project link show on every show.

5. The My Tasks tab

1. Click **My Tasks**. It lists the tasks assigned to you on this project.
2. Use **Filter tasks** to narrow the list as you type.
3. Click a row to select it. The status bar at the bottom then names the task that apps will launch against.
4. Right-click a row for everything you can do with it (section 6).

Column	Meaning
Task	The task name, e.g. Compositing.
Link	The shot or asset the task hangs off.
Step	The pipeline step — this decides the folder your scenes save into.
Status	The ShotGrid status. Change it in place from the right-click menu.
Latest version	The newest Version published against this task, so you can see where the work got to without opening anything.
Due	The task's due date.

A coloured dot on a row means that task needs attention — a note, a reply, or a version pushed back for changes. Hover it for the reason, or open **Needs Attention** for the full list.

Apps **My Tasks**

Filter tasks

Right-click a task to open its folder or launch an app

3 tasks

TASK	LINK	STEP	STATUS	LATEST VERSION	DUE
Compositing	SH010	Comp	IP		2026-10-02
Lighting	SH020	Light	RDY		2026-10-06
Animation	SH030	Anim	FIN		2026-09-29

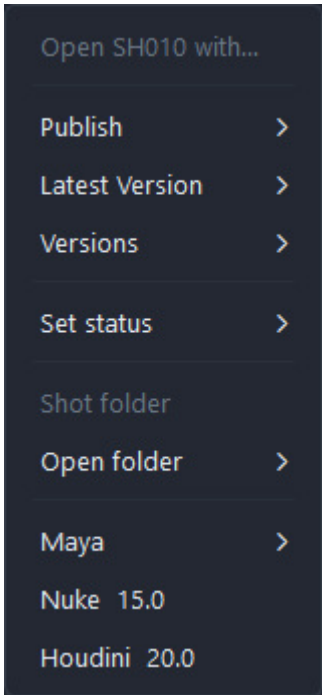
No task selected — apps launch without a publish context

My Tasks. Tasks are matched to you by email address, not by login name.

6. The task right-click menu

Right-clicking a task row is where most of Flow's work happens. The menu is built for the row you clicked, so every action already knows the project, shot, task and step.

Menu entry	What it does
Publish › Standalone Publish...	Upload a movie or an image to ShotGrid as a Version without opening a DCC. See section 9.
Latest Version ›	Jump straight to the newest Version on this task — play it, open it in RV, or open its page. Greyed out with a reason when nothing has been published yet.
Versions › View Versions	Open the version browser for this task (section 10). Disabled when the task has no shot or asset linked, because there would be nothing to browse.
Set status ›	Change the task's ShotGrid status in place. The choices are read from your site's own status list, so they match ShotGrid exactly.
Shot folder / Asset folder	Open the task's top folder in the file manager. Greyed out when the folder has not been created yet.
Open folder ›	The sub-folders — work, publish, renders and so on — plus Copy path . Entries that do not exist yet are greyed out rather than hidden, so you can see what the layout should be.
<DCC> <version>	The bottom band lists every DCC found in the studio package tree. Picking one launches it <i>against this task</i> — the part that matters (section 7).



The right-click menu on a task. The software at the bottom is scanned fresh each time you open the menu, so a newly released version appears without restarting Flow.

7. Launching a DCC against a task

1. Go to **My Tasks** and right-click the task you are working on.
2. Pick the application and version from the bottom of the menu — for example **Maya > 2024 (latest)**. A package with only one version installed appears as a single line instead of a submenu.
3. Flow resolves the package, injects the project environment and your task context, and starts the application.
4. The Terminal pane shows the resolved command and the context variables if you want to check them.
5. When the DCC finishes loading, a **5and8** menu is on its menu bar. That menu is how you save, version and publish (section 8).

Why launch from a task and not from Apps? The launch is what carries the context. Everything downstream — the folder your scene saves into, the version number, the publish name, the ShotGrid record — is derived from the task you launched against. A DCC opened from the Apps tab has no task, and its 5and8 menu will tell you to pick one and relaunch.

8. Inside the DCC — the 5and8 menu

Every supported host gets the same menu, in the same order. The two entries that leave your workstation — Publish and Submit — sit in a band of their own so neither is hit on the way to Save.

Menu item	What happens
Save	Saves over the scene that is open. If the scene has never been saved there is nothing to save over, so Flow tells you and runs Version Up instead rather than inventing a location.
Save As...	A save dialog that opens <i>on the task's work folder</i> with the correct next pipeline name already filled in. Pressing Enter gives you the convention; Save As is for the exception. If you save outside the work folder, Flow says so — files out there are not counted when

	working out the next version.
Version Up	Saves the open scene as the next version in the task's work folder. The number is one past the highest already on disk.
Publish...	Shows you exactly what will happen — version number, work path, publish path — and asks for confirmation. On OK it saves the scene, copies it into the publish folder under the same name, verifies the copy, and registers a PublishedFile in ShotGrid.
Submit to Deadline...	Saves the scene first (the farm renders the file on disk, so submitting unsaved would queue yesterday's work), then shows the plugin, frame range, pool and scene path for confirmation before the job is sent.
Open Work Folder	Opens the folder your scenes save into.
Open Publish Folder	Opens the folder publishes land in.
Context	Prints where you are — project, entity, task, step, software — and where the next save and the next publish would go. The first thing to check when anything looks wrong.

8.1 The naming convention

You never type a scene name. Flow builds it from the launch context:

```
uat6_SEQ001_AD1030_lighting_jitesh_v0001.ma
```

project · sequence · shot · step · artist · version, four digits.

The next version number is worked out from the files on disk, not from ShotGrid — so a slow or unreachable site can never block you from saving work in progress. If the file the next number points at somehow already exists, Flow refuses rather than overwriting it: someone else is probably working in the same folder.

8.2 Where files go

Work and publish folders sit beside each other under the shot or asset root, so "everything under **publish/** is safe to reference" stays true whatever anyone saves next door.

Host	Work folder	Publish folder	Scene
Maya	maya/scenes/<step>	maya/publish/<step>	.ma
Nuke	nuke/<step>/scene	nuke/<step>/publish	.nk
Houdini	houdini/hip/<step>	houdini/publish/<step>	.hip
Blender	blender/scenes/<step>	blender/publish/<step>	.blend
Silhouette	silhouette/<step>/scene	silhouette/<step>/publish	.sfx
3DEqualizer	3DE/<step>/scene	3DE/<step>/publish	.3de
Substance	substance/<step>/scene	substance/<step>/publish	.spp
Rhino	rhino/<step>/scene	rhino/<step>/publish	.3dm

If a **publish half-finishes** the file is already copied and verified on disk before ShotGrid is contacted, so a site outage means "published, not registered" — never a missing file. The message says exactly that, and a supervisor can register it afterwards.

9. Publishing without opening a DCC

Use this when what you have is already a movie or a frame — a playblast, a turntable, a render, a reference grab — and there is no scene to version.

1. In **My Tasks**, right-click the task and choose **Publish > Standalone Publish...**
2. Check the context block at the top: project, shot, task, department and the user the Version will be created under.
3. Drop your movie or image onto the dialog, or press **Choose Image / Movie....** Dropping a movie and a scene file together is understood as one gesture — both fields fill in.
4. Optionally point **the scene file this came from** at the .nk, .ma or .hip that produced it, so the Version records its source.
5. **Version name** is pre-filled with the next name in the convention. Leave it unless you have a reason.
6. Add a **Description** — what changed in this version. This is what a supervisor reads first.
7. Read the **preflight** panel. Green ticks are checks that passed; an amber row is a warning with the reason next to it. A warning does not stop you, but you must tick **I understand the warnings above** before **Publish Version** becomes available.
8. Press **Publish Version**. The result page confirms it, offers a box to post a note on the new Version, and a button to open it.

Publish a Version

Project: UAT6
Shot: SH010
Task: Compositing
Department: Comp
User: jitesh@5and8.ai

Drop a movie or image here, or browse for one Choose Image / Movie...

Optional — the scene file this came from (.nk, .ma, .hip ...) Browse...

Drop a file here

Version name: SH010_Comp_v004

Description: Optional — what changed in this version

Choose a file to run the publish preflight.

Media outside the project is allowed with a warning.

Cancel Publish Version

The publish dialog as it opens: context filled in, version name already correct, nothing chosen yet.

Publish a Version

ProjectUAT6

ShotSH010

TaskCompositing

DepartmentComp

Userjitesh@5and8.ai

/home/jitesh/Desktop/SH010_comp_v004.png

Choose Image / Movie...

Optional — the scene file this came from (.nk, .ma, .hip ...)

Browse...



Version name

SH010_Comp_v004

Description

Second grade pass, warmer key.

SH010_comp_v004.png

640 × 360 | RGB | 1.5 KB

CONTEXT

✓ Project: UAT6

✓ Shot: SH010

✓ Task: Compositing

✓ Department: Comp

PATH

⚠ That file is outside the approved project paths.

☐ I understand the warnings above and want to publish anyway

Media outside the project is allowed with a warning.

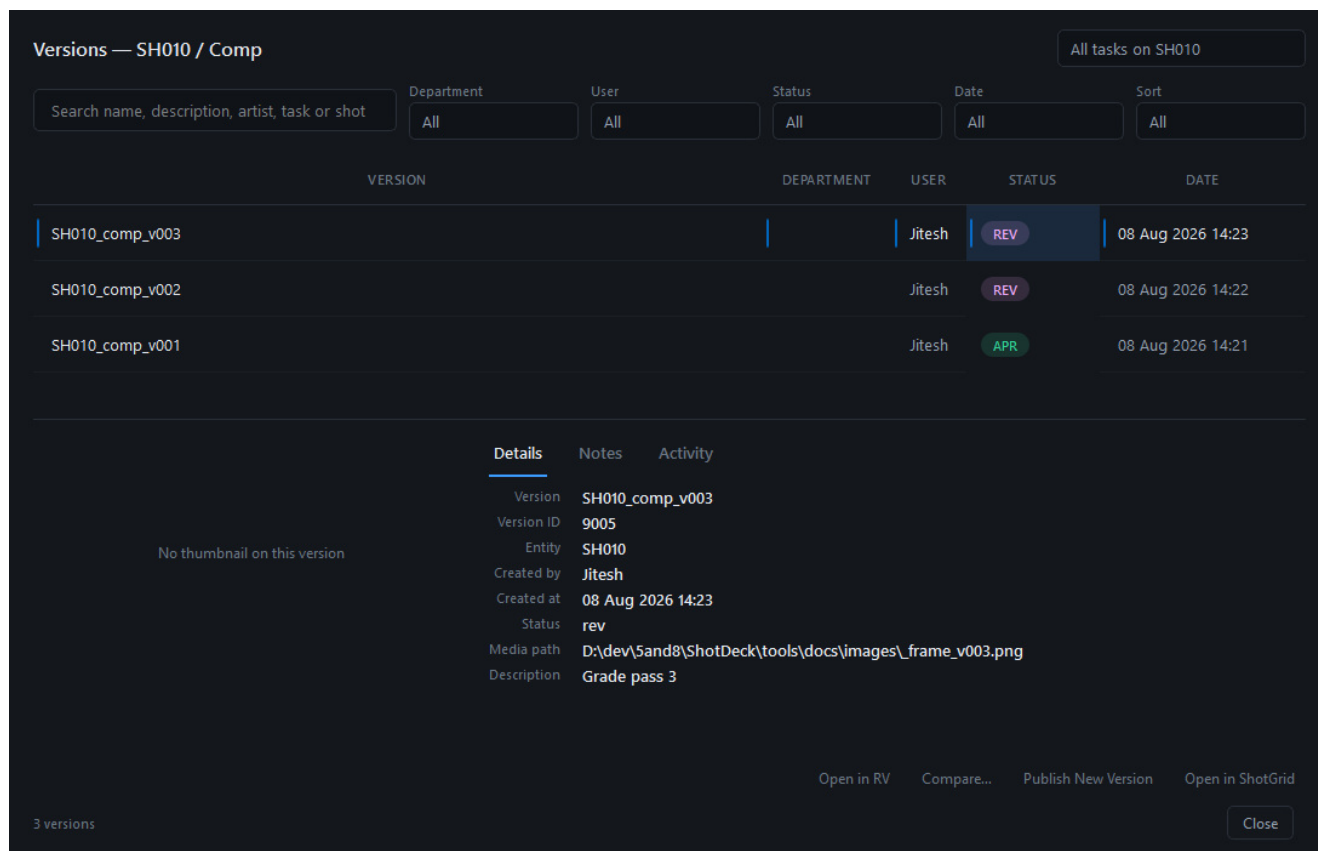
Cancel

Publish Version

After a file is chosen: thumbnail, resolution and size are read off the media, and the preflight has run. The amber row here is the media sitting outside the approved project paths.

10. Browsing versions

1. Right-click a task and choose **Versions > View Versions**.
2. The list opens newest first. The toggle at the top right switches between this task only and **All tasks on <shot>** — use it to see what lighting handed you before you comp it.
3. Narrow the list with the search box (it matches name, description, artist, task and shot) or the **Department, User, Status, Date** and **Sort** filters.
4. Click a version. Its thumbnail appears on the left and the tabs on the right fill in: **Details, Notes** and **Activity**.
5. Use the buttons along the bottom: **Play, Open in RV, Compare..., Publish New Version, Open in ShotGrid**.
6. **Load more** at the bottom pages through a long history rather than fetching thousands of rows up front.

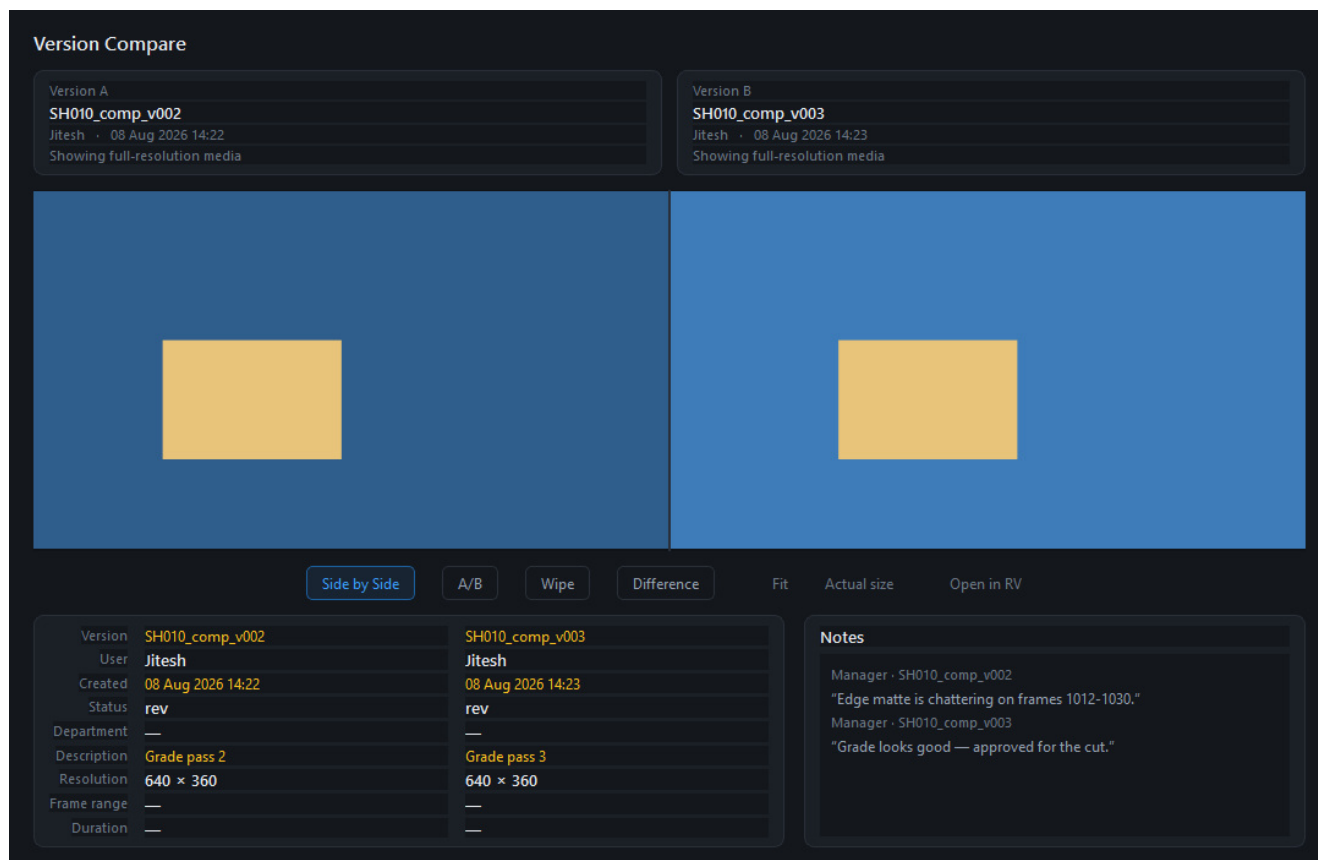


The version browser. Right-clicking a row gives the same actions as the buttons, plus copy-path and copy-name.

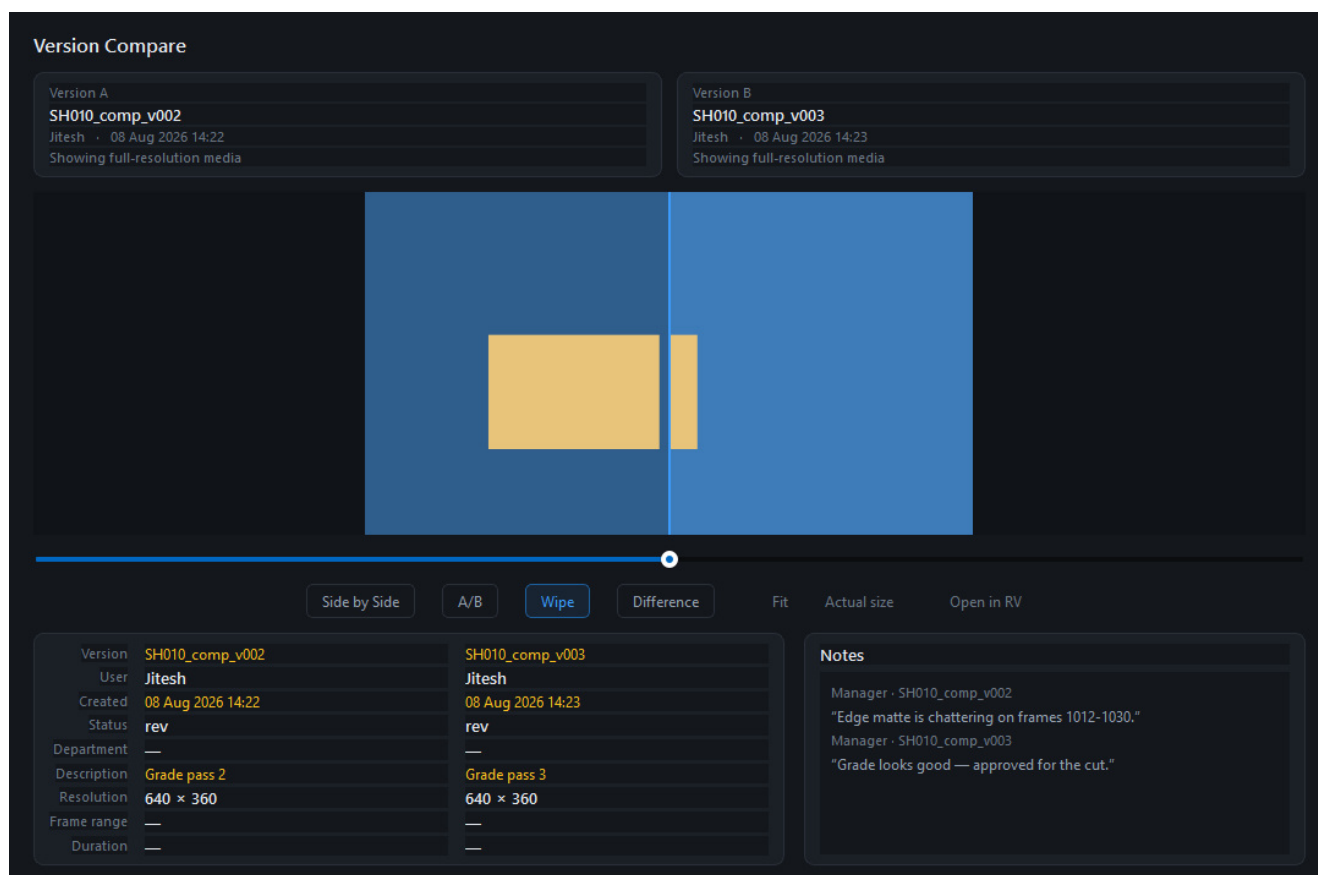
11. Comparing two versions

1. From the version browser, select a version and press **Compare...**; or from **Needs Attention**, press **Compare with previous** on a card.
2. Version A is on the left, version B on the right, each with its artist, date, and a line saying what it is showing — full-resolution media from this machine, or the ShotGrid thumbnail when the media is on a mount you do not have.
3. Switch viewing mode with the four buttons underneath.
4. **Fit** and **Actual size** control zoom; **Open in RV** hands both versions to RV when you need a real player.
5. The table at the bottom lists both versions field by field, with the differences highlighted. The notes on both versions are listed beside it, so you can read the feedback against the picture.

Mode	Use it for
Side by Side	General review — both frames at once.
A/B	Flipping one over the other in the same spot, which is how you catch a small move.
Wipe	Dragging a divider across the frame; best for grade and edge work.
Difference	What actually changed, and nothing else.



Side by Side.



Wipe, with the divider dragged to the middle.

12. Notes and replies

1. Open a version in the browser and click the **Notes** tab.
2. Each message shows who wrote it and their role — *artist, manager, client* — so you can tell a supervisor's note from a client's at a glance.
3. Type in **Add note** and press **Post Note** to leave feedback on that version.
4. Press **Reply** on a message to answer it; the button becomes **Post Reply** and **Cancel reply** backs out.
5. Your own messages have **Edit** and **Delete**. Other people's do not.
6. **Refresh Notes** re-reads the thread if someone is typing at the same time as you.
7. The **Activity** tab beside it is the version's history — status changes and events, not conversation.

The screenshot shows the 'Versions' page for 'SH010 / Comp'. At the top, there's a search bar and filters for Department, User, Status, Date, and Sort. Below this is a table of versions:

VERSION	DEPARTMENT	USER	STATUS	DATE
SH010_comp_v003		Jitesh	REV	08 Aug 2026 14:23
SH010_comp_v002		Jitesh	REV	08 Aug 2026 14:22
SH010_comp_v001		Jitesh	APR	08 Aug 2026 14:21

Below the table, the 'Notes' tab is selected for version SH010_comp_v003. It shows two messages:

- Rahul** (MANAGER) on 09 Aug 16:34: Grade looks good — approved for the cut.
- Jitesh** (ARTIST) on 09 Aug 17:02: (Message content is partially obscured)

At the bottom, there's an 'Add note' section with a text input and a 'Post Note' button. Other buttons like 'Open in RV', 'Compare...', 'Publish New Version', and 'Open in ShotGrid' are also visible.

The Notes tab: a supervisor's note and the artist's reply on the same version.

13. Needs Attention

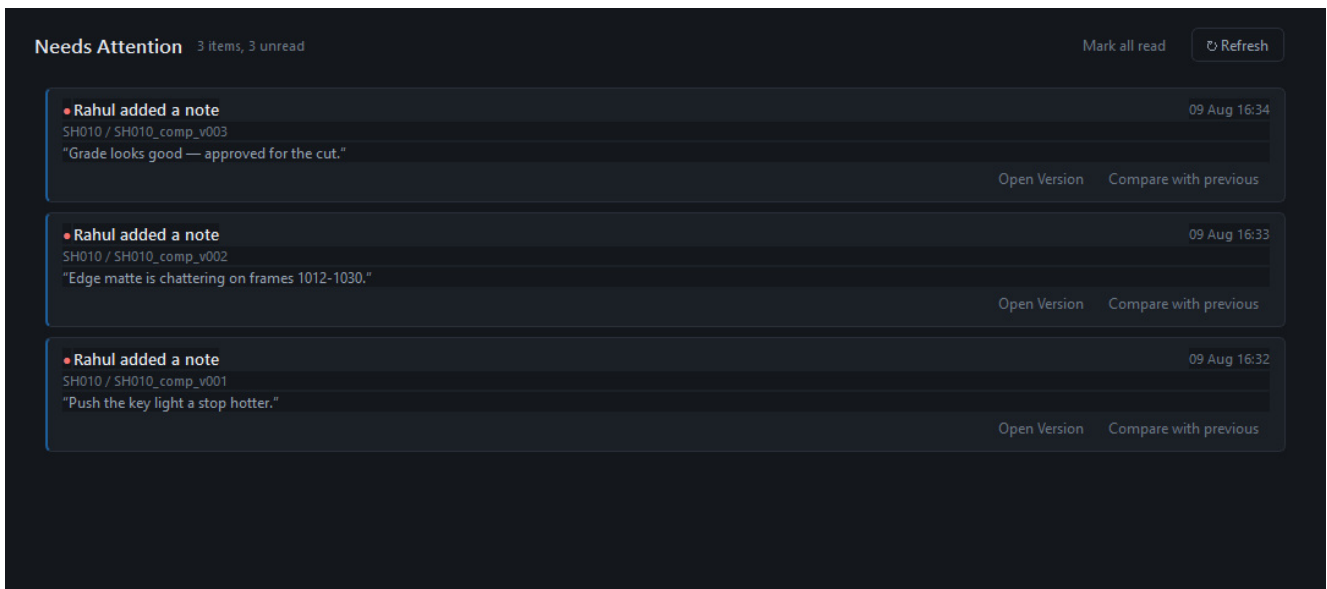
This is the "what changed while I was working" screen. It answers a different question from My Tasks, which is why it lives in the header with a count on it rather than as another tab.

It gathers three things:

- Notes somebody else left on **your** versions;
- Replies to notes **you** wrote, wherever those notes live;
- Versions a supervisor pushed back for changes.

1. Click **Needs Attention** in the header.
2. Unread items carry a dot. The header counts both totals — *3 items, 3 unread*.
3. Each card names who, what, which shot and version, when, and quotes the message.
4. **Open Version** takes you to it; **Compare with previous** puts it beside the version before it.
5. Opening an item marks it read. **Mark all read** clears the badge in one go; **Refresh** re-checks.

The same information drives the dot on task rows in My Tasks, so you can also see which task the feedback belongs to without coming here.

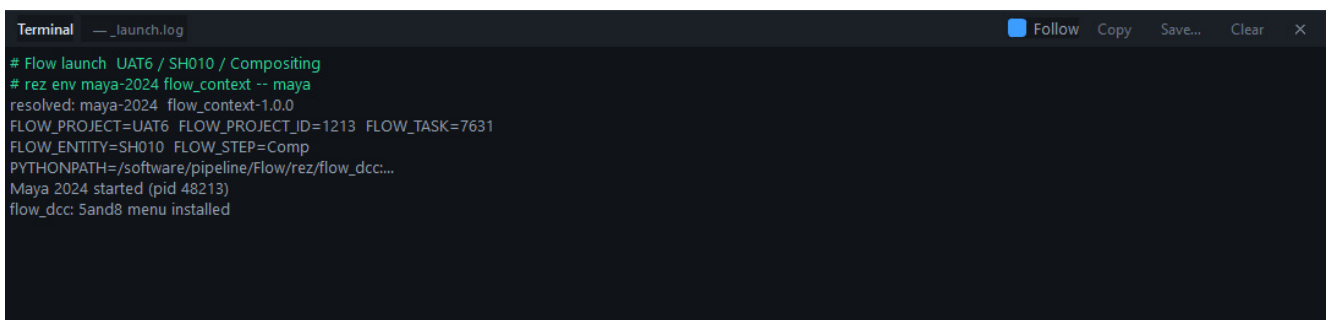


Needs Attention.

14. The Terminal pane

1. Press **Ctrl+`**, or click **Terminal** in the header.
2. It opens as a pane at the bottom of the window and follows what Flow is doing: the resolved package request, the command line, the environment variables handed to the DCC, and then the application's own output.
3. **Follow** keeps it scrolled to the newest line. Turn it off to read back without being dragged forward.
4. **Copy** puts the visible log on the clipboard, **Save...** writes it to a file, **Clear** empties the pane.
5. Close it with the **x**, the header button, or **Ctrl+`** again.

When you report a launch problem, this pane is what to send.



The Terminal following a Maya launch. Lines starting with # are the launch header Flow writes itself.

15. Keyboard shortcuts

Keys	Action
Ctrl+K	Focus Search my tasks in the header.
Ctrl+`	Show or hide the Terminal pane.
Esc	Close the dialog you are in.
Enter	In Save As inside a DCC: accept the pipeline name Flow suggested.

Flow can also be started with flags from a terminal:

```
flow.sh --verbose    log every command and environment detail
flow.sh --console    open with the Terminal pane already showing
```

16. When something goes wrong

What you see	What it means and what to do
My Tasks is empty	Flow matches tasks to you by <i>email address</i> , not login. Click your name chip: if the ShotGrid row says no user matched your address, your ShotGrid account has a different email on it. Send that line to your pipeline TD.
The Apps tab is empty	No Software entities are configured for this show. You can still launch a DCC by right-clicking a task — that path reads the studio package tree instead.
No 5and8 menu in the DCC	The DCC was not launched from Flow, or the pipeline package has not been rebuilt on this machine. Relaunch from a task; if it is still missing, that is one for the pipeline team.
"This session was launched without a task"	You launched from the Apps tab. Close the DCC, go to My Tasks, right-click the task and launch from there.
"The next version already exists on disk"	Someone else is probably saving into the same work folder. Check with them before saving — Flow will not overwrite it.
"Published, not registered"	The file is safely published on disk; only the ShotGrid record failed. Nothing is lost. Report it so the record can be created.
Compare says "no media on this machine"	The version's media is on a mount you do not have. Flow falls back to the ShotGrid thumbnail where there is one; otherwise ask for access to the mount.
A launch failed	Open the Terminal pane, press Copy , and paste it into your report. The resolved command and environment are in there.

Flow — 5and8. Screens in this guide are rendered from the application itself, so they stay in step with the build.